GREATER DES MOINES · ABOUT 60 MINUTES · VALLEY JUNCTION TO HOME

Haylee's Des Moines Tour

A one-hour drive from Valley Junction (stop 1) through the old heart of the city and back home, before apartment tours, so every address you see later has a place in your head. Scribble on this. Circle what you like, cross out what you don't.



Today's route · Interstates · Rivers · Numbered stops · Other places mentioned

~ Two rivers
The Raccoon runs along the bottom, just south of where we start, near home. The Des Moines River comes down from the top. They meet just south of downtown, where the city started.

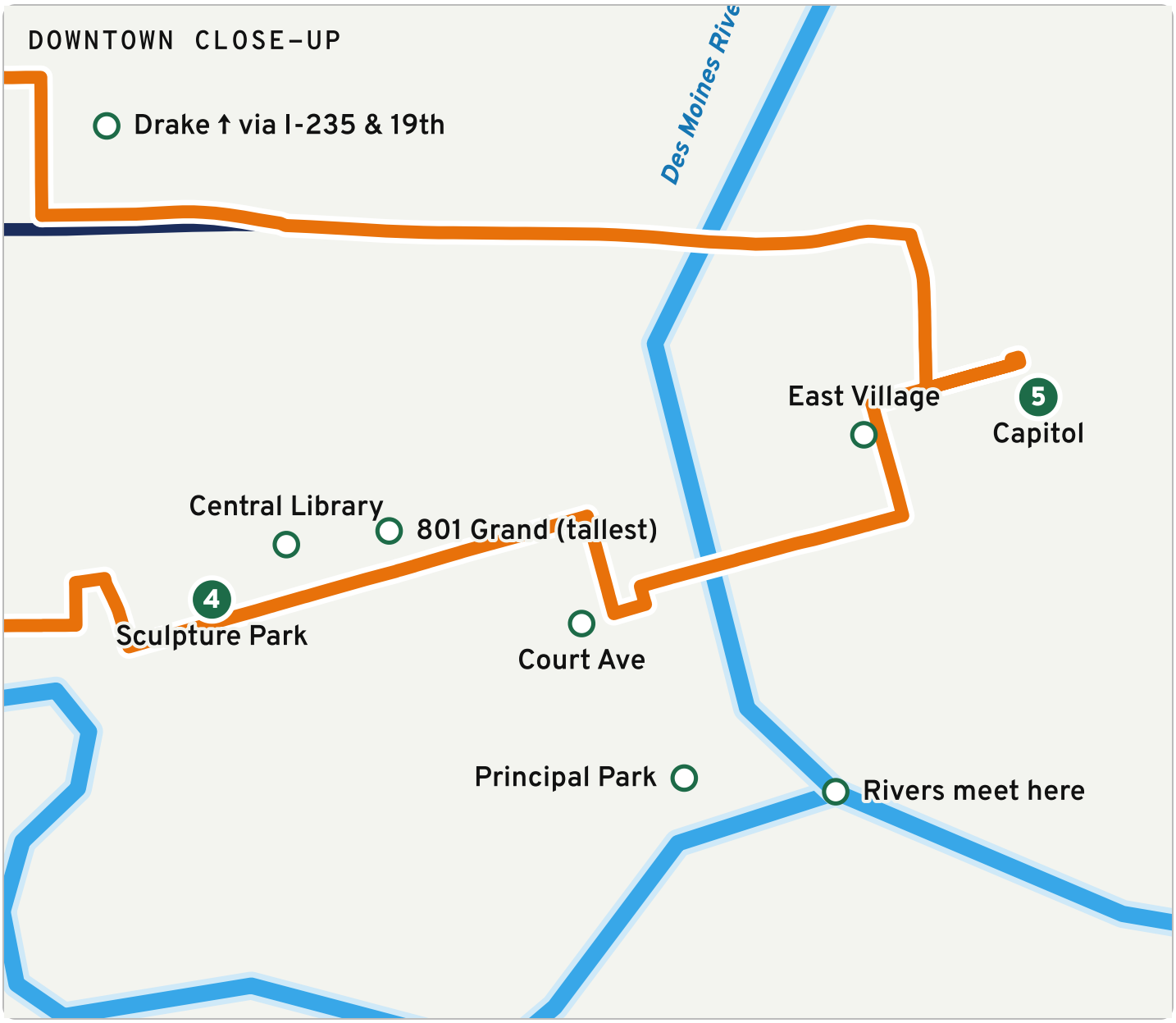
Street numbers
Bigger number, farther west. Small numbers (2nd, 3rd) are downtown. 63rd Street is the

235 I-235, the spine
Straight through the middle, east to west. Almost everywhere is about 5 minutes from it. Locals say "north of 235" or "south of 235."

35/80 35/80, the ring
Wraps the top and left edges like an upside-down L. Johnston and Ankeny are north along it; Clive and Waukee are west.

line between West Des Moines and Des Moines.

Downtown close-up



The stops

We'll mostly roll through, not park. Check a box when a place feels like you, and jot anything you want to ask about or come back to.

1

Valley Junction WEST DES MOINES · WHERE WE START

The old railroad town (1890s Rock Island repair shops). Once saloons and pool halls; flooded six feet deep in 1993; now boutiques, antiques, coffee and lots of independent salons on 5th Street.

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NOTES

2

Des Moines Art Center 4700 GRAND · FREE

Free art museum in Greenwood Park, with wings by three famous architects (one designed the Louvre pyramid). Rose garden, pond, trails. A calm afternoon alone.

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NOTES

3

Ingersoll & Terrace Hill GRAND AT 23RD

Ingersoll: an old streetcar street, now local restaurants and coffee. Terrace Hill: Iowa's first millionaire built it, went broke; now the governor lives on the top floor. Tours March–December by reservation.

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NOTES

4

Sculpture Park, library & skywalks DOWNTOWN WEST · FREE

Pappajohn Sculpture Park (Nomade, the letters man; Keith Haring; Kusama). Central Library next door. 4+ miles of skywalks connect 55 buildings. 801 Grand is Iowa's tallest building.

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NOTES

5

Court Ave, the river, East Village & Capitol DOWNTOWN

Court Ave: restaurants and the Saturday farmers' market (May–Oct). The rivers meet just south, where Fort Des Moines stood in 1843. East Village: Raygun, boutiques, salons. The Capitol: five domes, real gold, free to tour; see the law library.

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NOTES

6

Drake UNIVERSITY AVE · NORTH OF 235

Private college from 1881. Drake Relays every April, the Beautiful Bulldog contest, the Varsity Cinema. Apartments are older and cheaper; ask about August leases.

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NOTES

7

Beaverdale BEAVER AVE · LAST STOP BEFORE HOME

Old stagecoach road, brick-paved in 1917. Storybook "Beaverdale Brick" houses, a little shop strip and a fall festival parade. Mostly houses; small apartments only.

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NOTES

Apartment hunting cheat sheet

The same metro, sorted by what living there tends to feel like. These are broad strokes; the building matters more than the zip code.

AREA	FEEL	RENT	GOOD TO KNOW
West Des Moines / Jordan Creek	Newer complexes, shopping, quiet	$$	1BR roughly $1,000–1,250. Easy parking, everything in 10 min.
Waukee	Newest suburb, growing fast	$$	Lots of brand-new buildings; a bit farther from downtown.
Clive / Urbandale	Established suburbs	$–$$	Mix of older and newer complexes; near I-35/80.
Downtown / East Village	Walkable, lofts, nightlife	$$–$$$	Ask about parking costs and noise on weekend nights.
Ingersoll / Sherman Hill	Old houses split into apartments	$–$$	Lots of character; check heat, laundry and parking.
Drake	Student neighborhood	$	Cheaper; leases often follow the school year.
Johnston / Ankeny	Family suburbs to the north	$$	Nice and newer, but 20+ min to West Des Moines.

Apartments I'm touring

Write each one in, then find it on the map and mark it with its letter.

#	PLACE / ADDRESS	WHEN	RENT	GUT FEELING
A				
B				
C				
D				
E				

Questions to ask on tours

My questions & places to revisit

- What's included: water, trash, internet, parking?
- Is there a garage or covered spot? (Iowa winters.)
- Laundry in the unit or shared?
- Lease length options, and the move-in date?
- How are maintenance requests handled, and how fast?
- Pet policy and fees, even if just someday.

Places to come back to

You don't need anyone's permission. Put the address in your phone and go.

Quiet, free, good alone

- [ ] Des Moines Art Center (4700 Grand)
- [ ] Pappajohn Sculpture Park
- [ ] Central Library (get a free card)
- [ ] State Capitol + law library
- [ ] Jordan House museum (Fri & Sun tours)
- [ ] Varsity Cinema near Drake

Walk around & look at shops

- [ ] Valley Junction, 5th St (5 min from home)
- [ ] East Village (Raygun, boutiques, salons)
- [ ] Ingersoll Ave restaurants & coffee
- [ ] Beaverdale shops on Beaver Ave
- [ ] Jordan Creek Town Center
- [ ] Reese Marie salons: Cumming & Valley Junction

Outside

- [ ] Gray's Lake: 2-mile loop, rainbow bridge at night
- [ ] Principal Riverwalk
- [ ] Brenton outdoor ice rink (winter)
- [ ] Saylorville Lake beach (summer)
- [ ] Living History Farms
- [ ] Middlebrook: town garden, u-pick flowers, Wilson's Orchard

On the calendar

- [ ] Downtown Farmers' Market: Saturdays, May–Oct
- [ ] Drake Relays: late April
- [ ] Des Moines Arts Festival: June
- [ ] Iowa State Fair: Aug 12–22, 2027 (butter cow!)
- [ ] Beaverdale Fall Festival: September
- [ ] Iowa Cubs at Principal Park: summer

My notes